



Leadership in Action (LIA)

Ethical Engagement Guidelines

Ethical Engagement

Ethical engagement is the practice of collaborating with others in a way that is just, reciprocal, and mindful of power dynamics, prioritising mutual benefit and long-term positive impact.

Ethical engagement ensures that your LIA:

- Aligns with community priorities: responding to needs identified by those directly impacted.
- Centres collaboration: you are a learner, collaborator, and facilitator, not a saviour.
- Respects local expertise: recognising that communities are already driving change.
- Creates sustainable impact: your work should be meaningful beyond your six weeks.

Collaboration > intervention

Sustainability > quick fixes

Reflection > assumption

Why does it matter?

- 🚫 **Avoiding harm:** even with good intentions, projects can have unintended consequences if they are not community-led.
- 🌱 **Building trust & sustainability:** ethical engagement helps your impact be meaningful and continue after you leave.
- 🎯 **Becoming a better leader:** it builds your ability to listen, reflect, and navigate complexity, shaping you into a more effective and responsible leader.

Key Elements of an Ethically-Engaged LIA





Community-Led & Locally-Driven Approach



Community-Led & Locally-Driven Approach

Your LIA should amplify and support community-led efforts, ensuring that solutions come from within the community, rather than being imposed externally.

Partnering with local organisations or grassroots leaders already engaged in long-term work.

Listening and learning before acting - understanding the community's priorities, strengths, and existing strategies.

Working within & strengthening existing structures, rather than creating parallel or short-lived initiatives.



Community-Led & Locally-Driven Approach

Guiding Questions:

How were the needs, goals, or focus of the project identified, and by whom?

How am I supporting long-term, community-led efforts rather than introducing my own agenda?

What assumptions might I be bringing about what this community “needs”?



Sustainable, Transformative Impact & Continuity



Sustainable, Transformative Impact & Continuity

Ethical engagement goes beyond temporary aid, it contributes to systemic, lasting change.

Avoiding projects that alleviate symptoms rather than address root causes.

Building capacity, not dependency - your presence should empower local efforts rather than create reliance on outside support.

Ensuring continuity by supporting local partners to lead, staying engaged beyond your LIA, or laying the foundation for future Scholars to contribute meaningfully.



Sustainable, Transformative Impact & Continuity

Guiding Questions:

What lasting value will this project bring to the community after I leave?

How does this work address deeper, systemic challenges, not just immediate needs?

Have I considered how I or others might continue the work beyond the 6 weeks?



Skill-Based & Strengths-Oriented Contributions



Skill-Based & Strengths-Oriented Contributions

Your contributions should be relevant and add real value without undermining local professionals or reinforcing extractive power dynamics.

Contributing where you have genuine expertise, not stepping into roles you are unprepared for (e.g. teaching subjects you do not understand, engaging in medical care without training).

Recognising when to support rather than lead - understanding that leadership is not always about being at the forefront; sometimes it means stepping back and creating space for others.

Ensuring your work adds value without displacing local professionals - being mindful that your presence should strengthen, not replace, existing efforts within the community.



Skill-Based & Strengths-Oriented Contributions

Guiding Questions:

Do I have the skills and knowledge to do this work responsibly?

Am I stepping into a role that could displace or undervalue local professionals?

How am I adding value based on the community's priorities, not just my own interests?



Reciprocity & Mutual Exchange



Reciprocity & Mutual Exchange

The LIA should not be a one-sided “service” project where you ‘give’ and communities ‘receive’. Engagement should be mutual and non-extractive, ensuring that both Scholars and communities benefit in equitable ways.

Recognising and valuing local expertise - communities are active co-creators, not passive recipients.

Avoiding extractive engagement - ensuring that you are not benefiting from or documenting experiences without meaningful contributions in return.

Building genuine relationships based on trust, respect, and accountability rather than transactional, one-off interactions.



Reciprocity & Mutual Exchange

Guiding Questions:

How is this a two-way exchange where both I and the community benefit?

How am I ensuring that my engagement is non-extractive?

Am I building relationships based on trust, not just transaction?



Cultural Humility & Awareness



Cultural Humility & Awareness

Ethical engagement requires more than 'respect' for different cultural contexts and norms. It requires critical awareness of power, privilege, and history.

Engaging with the historical, social, and political context of the community, not just observing cultural "differences."

Being conscious of power dynamics - avoiding paternalism, saviour narratives, or reinforcing harmful stereotypes.

Redefining 'success' - understanding that impact may look different across cultural, social, and political contexts.



Cultural Humility & Awareness

Guiding Questions:

How does my identity (race, gender, class, nationality) shape my role in this context?

Have I taken time to understand the cultural, historical, social, & political contexts of this community?

Have I reflected on and challenged any unconscious biases I may be bringing with me?



Environmental & Economic Sustainability



Environmental & Economic Sustainability

Your LIA should be mindful of both environmental and financial sustainability.

Minimising environmental harm and considering the ecological footprint of your work - avoiding unnecessary travel, wasteful initiatives, and unsustainable resource use.

Using funding effectively – ensuring it benefits the community in meaningful and transparent ways.

Supporting local economies by working with community-based vendors, service providers, and suppliers.



Environmental & Economic Sustainability

Guiding Questions:

How am I minimising environmental harm (e.g. unnecessary travel, waste)?

How am I supporting the local economy?

Could the community carry this work forward without external funding?



Accountability & Continuous Reflection



Accountability & Continuous Reflection

Ethical engagement is an ongoing practice, requiring critical self-reflection and openness to feedback.

Interrogating your motivations
- asking yourself why you are
doing this project and who
truly benefits.

Anticipating unintended
consequences - recognising
and addressing potential
harm.

Committing to accountability -
seeking honest, critical
feedback from partners and
adjusting your approach
based on their insights.



Accountability & Continuous Reflection

Guiding Questions:

Why am I *really* doing this project, and who benefits most from it?

How am I creating space for feedback, even when it's uncomfortable?

How am I reflecting on my own assumptions, motivations, and growth?

What We Want to Avoid

- ❌ **Voluntourism:** the LIA is not about short-term, feel-good experiences that prioritise your learning over the community's long-term needs. You must recognise that partners are not there to "host" you, they have their own priorities and responsibilities.
- ❌ **The “Saviour” Mindset:** you are not coming in to "rescue" or "fix" a community. The LIA should be about collaboration, not intervention, and you should be aware that working with a partner is not the same as being "needed" by one. You should ensure your project aligns with existing efforts, rather than creating extra burdens for local teams.
- ❌ **Top-Down Decision-Making:** the LIA should not displace local expertise or impose external solutions. You should be flexible and adaptive, recognising that many community organisations may not have the capacity for intensive training or supervision. Instead of assuming you will be given structured tasks, you should take initiative, listen, and contribute in ways that add value without increasing pressure on an already stretched team.
- ❌ **Short-Term, Unsustainable Work:** you should avoid one-off interventions that fail to address long-term impact or unintentionally leave a burden behind. ‘Sustainable’ doesn’t mean solving everything in 6 weeks. It means your contributions strengthen ongoing efforts and leave something useful behind - knowledge, tools, or connections that can outlast your stay.